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Multimedia Is the Message

Two battles were fought in the elections of 2014. One was the traditional battle across the heat and dust of a vast country, in basti and maidan, in street corner and chai shop; the other on a television screen near you. Election 2014 was India's first general election where television became the defining arena of the contest.

In 1989—the first election I covered as a journalist—only Doordarshan was on air. In 2004, there were half a dozen major 'national channels' and about a dozen regional channels. By 2014, the information and broadcasting ministry list suggested that there were almost 400 24/7 news and current affairs channels beaming out of India, a crazy number, way more than any other country in the world. It was a mini revolution that was changing the way Indians consumed and communicated news. Television defined politics, politics was played for television. The TV top story often engulfed the political class. Every evening as channels stampeded towards the prime-time headline, netas and commentators were at hand as the ever-ready chorus.

In the 2004 elections, when I broke the story of Sonia Gandhi opting out of the prime ministerial race, I was, for at least a couple of hours, onto a genuine 'exclusive'. I was actually able to stand outside 10, Janpath, and broadcast my report without being bothered by a forest of other cameras. By 2014, the idea of a news 'exclusive' was lost. Within minutes, every channel would be onto the story. Often, several channels would flash the same newsbreak or interview as an 'exclusive'.

The idea of breaking news, in particular, has 'broken down'—even a piece of trivia is now breaking news. The new newsroom mantra is to keep